

Card Deck

A dozen games for a standard 52-card deck

House rules written for The Game Room. These are the common rules for each game; plenty of tables play their own variations, so agree on any before you start.

Euchre (4 players, two partnerships)

Use 24 cards: the 9, 10, J, Q, K and A of each suit. Partners sit opposite each other. Deal 5 cards each, turn the next card face up and set the rest aside.

Choosing trump: starting left of the dealer, each player may tell the dealer to pick up the face-up card, making its suit trump, or pass. If someone orders it up, the dealer takes it and discards a card. If everyone passes, the card is turned down and, starting left of the dealer again, each player may name a different suit as trump or pass. If everyone passes twice, redeal. The team that chose trump are the makers. The player who chose trump may go alone, and their partner sits out the hand.

Card order in trump: the jack of trump (right bower) is highest, then the other jack of the same colour (left bower, which counts as a trump), then A, K, Q, 10, 9. Other suits run A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, except that the suit of the same colour as trump has lost its jack to the left bower.

Play: the player left of the dealer leads. Follow suit if you can; otherwise play anything. The highest trump wins the trick, or the highest card of the suit led if no trump was played. The winner leads next.

Scoring: makers who take 3 or 4 tricks score 1; all 5 tricks score 2; a lone hand taking all 5 scores 4. Makers who take fewer than 3 are euchred and the other team scores 2. First team to 10 wins.

Spades (4 players, two partnerships)

Deal all 52 cards, 13 each. Each player bids the number of tricks they expect to take; a partnership's bids add up to its contract. A bid of nil means you will take no tricks at all.

The player left of the dealer leads. Follow suit if you can; otherwise play anything. Spades are always trump. Spades cannot be led until one has been played on another suit, unless you hold nothing but spades.

Scoring: make your contract and score 10 points per trick bid, plus 1 per extra trick (a bag). Fall short and lose 10 per trick bid. Every 10 bags costs 100 points. A successful nil scores 100 and a failed nil loses 100; the partner's tricks count separately. First partnership to 500 wins.

Hearts (4 players, every player for themselves)

Deal all 52 cards, 13 each. Before each hand, pass three cards: to the left, then to the right, then across, then no pass, and repeat.

The player holding the 2 of clubs leads it. Follow suit if you can; otherwise play anything. There is no trump: the highest card of the suit led wins the trick. Hearts cannot be led until a heart has been played on another suit, unless you hold nothing but hearts. By common house rule, no hearts or queen of

spades may be played on the first trick.

Scoring: each heart you take is 1 point and the queen of spades is 13. Take every heart and the queen of spades (shooting the moon) and you score 0 while everyone else scores 26. When someone reaches 100, the lowest score wins.

Crazy Eights (2 to 7 players)

Deal 5 cards each (7 each with two players). Turn the top card of the stock face up to start the discard pile.

On your turn, play a card that matches the top discard's rank or suit. Eights are wild: play one at any time and name the suit to follow. If you cannot play, draw from the stock until you can.

The first player out of cards wins the hand. To keep score, the winner collects points for everyone else's cards: 50 per eight, 10 per face card, 1 per ace and face value for the rest.

President (4 to 8 players)

Deal out the whole deck. Cards rank 3 (low) up to A, with 2 the highest.

The leader plays a single card, a pair, three or four of a kind. Each following player must play the same number of cards of a higher rank, or pass. When everyone passes, the last player to play clears the pile and leads again.

The first player out becomes President and the last becomes Scum. At the start of the next hand, Scum gives the President their two best cards and the President gives back any two.

Spoons (3 or more players)

Put spoons in the middle of the table, one fewer than the number of players. Deal 4 cards each.

The dealer draws from the deck, keeps 4 cards and passes one face down to the left. Everyone keeps passing a card left as fast as they can, and the last player discards. You are trying to collect four of a kind.

Whoever gets four of a kind quietly takes a spoon, and then everyone grabs one. The player left without a spoon takes a letter of S-P-O-O-N; spell it and you are out.

Egyptian Ratscrew (2 to 6 players)

Deal out the whole deck face down; nobody looks at their cards. In turn, flip your top card onto the middle pile.

When an ace or face card is played, the next player gets a limited number of flips to play another ace or face card: 4 for an ace, 3 for a king, 2 for a queen, 1 for a jack. If they turn up an ace or face card in time, the challenge passes to the next player; if they fail, whoever played the last ace or face card takes the pile.

Anyone may slap the pile when the top two cards match in rank (a double) or when the top card matches the one two below it (a sandwich), and the first to slap takes the pile. A wrong slap costs a card

under the pile. A player with no cards can still slap back in. Win by collecting every card.

Speed (2 players)

Each player takes a 20-card draw pile and picks up 5 cards from it as a hand. Place two face-down piles of 5 cards in the middle as spares, and put the last two cards face down between them.

Both players flip one of the two middle cards at the same time to start two centre piles. Then, as fast as you like and without taking turns, play a card from your hand onto either centre card if it is one rank higher or lower (ace connects to both king and 2). Keep your hand at 5 cards by drawing from your pile.

If neither player can play, both flip a new card from the spares onto the centre piles. The first player to run out of cards in hand and pile wins.

Gin Rummy (2 players)

Deal 10 cards each. Turn the next card face up to start the discard pile; the rest is the stock.

On your turn, take the top card of the stock or the discard pile, then discard one card. You are building melds: three or four cards of the same rank, or three or more cards in sequence in one suit (ace is low). Cards outside melds are deadwood: face cards count 10, aces 1, others face value.

When your deadwood totals 10 or less you may knock: lay out your melds and deadwood. Your opponent lays out theirs and may add cards to your melds. If your deadwood is lower, you score the difference. Going gin (no deadwood) scores the difference plus 25, and your opponent may not add to your melds. If the opponent's deadwood is equal or lower, they score the difference plus 25. First to 100 wins.

Golf (2 to 6 players)

Deal 6 cards face down to each player, laid out in two rows of three. Each player turns any two face up. Turn the next card face up to start the discard pile.

On your turn, draw from the stock or take the top discard. Swap it for one of your six cards (the new card goes face up and the old one is discarded), or, if you drew from the stock, discard it unused.

When one player has all six cards face up, everyone else gets one more turn. Score: ace 1, 2 counts minus 2, number cards face value, jacks and queens 10, kings 0, and a matching pair in the same column counts 0. Play nine hands; the lowest total wins.

Go Fish (2 to 6 players)

Deal 7 cards each (5 each with four or more players). The rest is the pond.

On your turn, ask one player for a rank you already hold. If they have any, they hand them all over and you go again. If not, they say "go fish" and you draw from the pond; if you draw the rank you asked for, show it and go again.

Lay down every set of four (a book). When all thirteen books are made, the player with the most wins.

Klondike Solitaire (1 player)

Deal seven piles left to right of 1 to 7 cards, with only the top card of each face up. The rest is the stock.

Build the piles down in alternating colours (a red 9 on a black 10). You may move a whole face-up run, and turn up any face-down card that is uncovered. Only a king, or a run starting with a king, may fill an empty pile.

Turn cards from the stock one at a time (or three, for a harder game) onto a waste pile; its top card is in play. Move aces to four foundation piles and build each up by suit to the king. You win when all 52 cards are on the foundations.